

MarEng Grammar

NOUNS

A noun can be COUNTABLE or UNCOUNTABLE. Compare the two types:

Countable

- John has a car.
- Andrew has three cars.

Car is a countable noun.

Countable nouns are things we can count.

We can say one car, two cars.

Other examples :

- There is **a town** nearby.
- There is **a port** in Santander.
- It is not your fault. It was **an accident**.
- There are many **vehicles** on board.
- The Marina has **a cargo** of containers.
- It was **a fine day**.
- We sailed on **a stormy sea** under **a grey sky**.

We use **the indefinite article a or an** with **singular countable nouns**.

a ship a cargo an apple an orange

an is used **before** words starting with **a vowel sound** (a, e, i, u, o, y)

Uncountable

- There is snow everywhere.
- I like snow in winter.

Snow is an uncountable noun.

Uncountable nouns are things we cannot count. We cannot say one snow, two snows.

Other examples:

- This table is made of **wood** and **glass**.
- **Butter** is expensive.
- This ship is made of **steel**.
- **Grain, rice, ore, and sodium carbonate** are **dry bulk**.
- **Oil, petroleum and liquid gas** are **liquid bulk**.
- Finland produces **paper** and **pulp**.

NOTE: Names of **substances** are often **uncountable**.

We use **no indefinite article a or an** with **uncountable nouns**.

We do not say an oil or a cotton.

BUT: We can use a countable noun as a measure. **a...of...**

- a glass of water
- a cup of coffee
- a barrel of oil
- a bale of cotton
- a carton of tobacco
- a container of fruit

Plural countable nouns usually have the ending **-s** or **-es**.

(See Plurals for more information.)

- **Accidents** happen.
- There were **flowers** everywhere.
- **Boys** will be **boys**.

NOTE: Referring to a whole species:

- **Dogs** do not like **cats**.
- **Doctors** are paid more than **teachers**.

Uncountable nouns have only **one form**. They have **no plural ending** and are used **without a/ an**.

NOTE: Some abstract nouns in a general sense are used in the same way.

- **Life** is interesting.
- **Death** comes to all.
- **Time** is **money**.

(See The definite article-section for more information.)